

Embedded documentation

The data or document itself may contain information about a file or dataset. This means that documentation for digital datasets can be contained in separate files (for example, text files) or integrated into the data file(s), either as a header or at specific points inside the file. Examples of embedded documentation include:

- code, field and label descriptions
- descriptive headers or summaries
- recording information in the Document Properties function of a file (Microsoft)

Supporting documentation

This is material contained in separate files that accompany data and serves to provide context, explanation, or instructions on data confidentiality, usage, or reuse. Examples of supporting documentation include:

- Working papers or laboratory books
- Questionnaires or interview guides
- Final project reports and publications
- Catalogue metadata

The supporting documentation should be formatted in such a way that it may be used to identify and locate the data via a web browser or web-based cataloguing system. When materials are deposited, repositories or data centres often format the metadata according to an international standard and associate it with the data. The following are some examples of catalogue data:

- Title
- Description
- Creator
- Funder
- Keywords
- Affiliation

Tools for metadata tracking and data standards

ISA Tools

The open source ISA metadata tracking tools assist in the management of a growing variety of life science, environmental, and biomedical studies that involve one or more technologies.